

Aakansha Jain

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics , Iowa State University	Aug 2022 – May 2027 (expected)
M.Sc. in Economics , Shiv Nadar University, India	2018–2020
B.Sc. in Economics , Lady Brabourne College, University of Calcutta, India	2014–2017

Minor: Mathematics & Statistics; First-Class Honours.

FIELDS OF INTEREST

Labor Economics, Agricultural Labor, Development Economics, Rural Development, Economics of Education, Migration, Applied Microeconomics

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Manternach, R., Jain, A., Orazem, P.F., & Soborowicz, L. (2025). “Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?” *Growth and Change*, 56(4): e70064.

Book Chapters

Jain, A., Montenegro, C., & Orazem, P.F. (forthcoming, 2026). “Youth Labor Markets in High- and Low-Income Countries.” In K. Leicht (Ed.), *Oxford University Handbook on the 21st Century Economy*. Oxford University Press.

WORKING PAPERS

“The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor” *Job Market Paper*
solo-authored

Abstract. The H-2A agricultural guestworker visa program, which enables U.S. farmers to legally hire foreign labor for seasonal farm jobs, grew more than fourfold between 2008 and 2024. Simultaneously, the settled non-citizen workforce that had long supplied the same seasonal farm labor shrank under intensified immigration enforcement. Two thirds of these settled non-citizen agricultural workers in the U.S. lack work authorization. This paper asks whether the decline in settled farm workers caused the rise of the H-2A visa program, and at what rate. Using a panel of 740 commuting zones, I instrument the contemporaneous settled non-citizen share of agricultural labor with its 2000 baseline share interacted with national enforcement shifts. I find that farms hire 1.7 H-2A guestworkers for each settled non-citizen worker lost in headcount, and approximately one for one in labor time. H-2A hiring responds with a lag of four years after the settled workforce begins to decline in 2015. Substitution for lost settled workers accounts for about 42 percent of aggregate H-2A growth over the period.

“College Wage Premiums in India: Trends and Spatial Decomposition, 1987–2012 [\[link\]](#)” *Solo-authored, 2025*

Abstract. This paper traces the college-versus-high-school earnings gap in India across five waves of the National Sample Survey, 1987–2012, a period when tertiary enrollment nearly tripled. I estimate Mincer wage equations and two-part Cragg models that separate labor-force participation from pay, organized into synthetic birth cohorts. The college premium rose substantially throughout the period for both younger and older workers. Zone-level decompositions, motivated by imperfect substitution between young and old

workers, show that the young–old premium gap closed where college supply expanded most and persisted where it did not.

“An Overview of the 2024 Iowa State University Alumni Survey
[RePEc]”

with A. Andrade, J. Eyles, K.
Kimle, P.F. Orazem, and R.
Unal

Abstract. This paper documents the design, sample construction, and descriptive findings of the 2024 Iowa State University alumni survey, a follow-up to the 2008 survey (Jolly, Yu, and Orazem 2009). Covers cohorts graduating from 1982 to 2023, with over 5,000 usable Bachelor’s-degree responses. Reports patterns of entrepreneurship, employment, education, and geographic mobility across 41 years of ISU graduates, with results weighted to reflect the underlying alumni population. Serves as the primary data reference for subsequent policy briefs and working papers drawing on the 2024 survey. Working Paper 25007, Department of Economics, Iowa State University.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

“Does Broadband Close the Rural Education Gap?”

with L. Han and J.V. Winters

Abstract. This paper examines whether federally subsidized broadband in high-cost areas raises college enrollment among rural high-school graduates. The mechanism is a reduction in the information frictions that constrain the college-going decision. Identification exploits the Connect America Fund Phase II Price Cap program, whose block-level eligibility was determined ex ante by a 2014 FCC engineering cost model and is therefore plausibly exogenous to local education outcomes. The empirical strategy is a staggered difference-in-differences design that compares eligible census blocks by the timing of broadband deployment, with never-deployed eligible blocks serving as the comparison group. The analysis links HUBB deployment records to restricted-access American Community Survey microdata through the Iowa State University Federal Statistical Research Data Center (Project 3044; security clearance complete, data access imminent).

“Returns to Farming Among ISU Alumni”

with I. Cho and P.F. Orazem

Abstract. This paper estimates the household-income returns to farming among Iowa State University graduates, using the alumni surveys with propensity-score matching and an endogenous treatment-effects model. Farm households earn roughly a third less than observationally similar nonfarm households, a result robust across estimators. The geography of the gap depends on how farming is defined: under a broad definition, the disadvantage is concentrated outside rural areas, while among full-time farmers it remains large and statistically significant within rural areas as well. Household income does not capture farmland wealth or the nonpecuniary benefits of farming, so lower income need not imply lower overall well-being. Entry into farming is driven mainly by family farming background and family-business experience.

“Firm Entry and Serial Entrepreneurship Among ISU Alumni”

with D. Lin and P.F. Orazem

Abstract. This paper examines how local labor market conditions at graduation shape the timing of entrepreneurial entry among Iowa State University alumni, using the 2008 and 2024 alumni surveys. Estimating probit models of business entry at horizons from one to forty years after graduation, it finds that a higher Iowa unemployment rate at graduation has no early effect but a significant, persistent negative effect that emerges around year 5, deepens through years 10 to 14, and fades by year 20. The national unemployment rate shows no such effect, indicating that local rather than national conditions are what delay entrepreneurial entry.

POLICY REPORTS

- Crespi, G., and Jain, A. (2026). “Where Do They Go? Migration Patterns of Iowa State University Alumni.” *Agricultural Policy Review*, Winter 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University. [\[link\]](#)

- Andrade, A., Eyles, J., Jain, A., Kimle, K., Orazem, P.F., & Unal, R. (2025). "How a Land Grant College Affects Business and Job Creation." *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2025. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University. [\[link\]](#)

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

Media Mentions

- "Iowa State college graduates left for bigger cities, but they're returning to Iowa." *Axios Des Moines*, April 21, 2026. Coverage of Crespi and Jain (2026). [\[link\]](#)

Outreach Writing

- Jain, A. (2024). "How to Compute Real Income or Real Value of a Given Currency?" *Ask an Economist*, Department of Economics, Iowa State University, November 6, 2024. [\[link\]](#)

CONFERENCES AND PRESENTATIONS

- Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting, Houston, TX Nov 2026
Selected Paper: JMP.
- Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA), Kansas City, MO Jul 2026
Selected Paper: JMP.
- Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL Mar 2025
"Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?"

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record, Iowa State University

ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions Spring 2025
Instructor of record for 60 students. Designed the course syllabus, prepared all lecture slides, managed homework and in-class quizzes using the Pearson platform, and coordinated with a teaching assistant for grading. Topics included monetary policy, central banking, financial regulation, and international finance.

Teaching Assistant, Iowa State University

- ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics Spring 2026
Assisted with Friday lectures and prepared and graded weekly quizzes.
- ECON 2070: Quantitative Methods in Economic Analysis I Fall 2025
Conducted weekly math-focused lab sessions for 30 students; opened each session with a guided example and supported students in applying quantitative methods to economic problems.
- ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions Fall 2024
Attended all lectures to provide continuous student support; conducted review sessions before exams, solved practice problems in class, and graded written exams.
- ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics (Online, Accelerated) Winter 2024
Taught an intensive one-month asynchronous section; recorded comprehensive review sessions and hosted live Q&A discussions.
- ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics Fall 2023
Led independent biweekly recitations reviewing lecture content and exam materials; facilitated in-class discussions and addressed conceptual questions.

- ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics (Online) Spring 2023
Managed student communication in a fully online course; resolved queries via email, maintained virtual office hours, and supported engagement in an asynchronous format.
- ECON 1010L: Principles of Microeconomics Lab Fall 2022
Guided students through core microeconomic concepts in weekly lab sessions; clarified problem-solving methods, graded lab assignments, and provided individualized support.

Mentorship

- Help Room Tutor Spring 2023 – Fall 2024
Assisted students across principles and intermediate courses during weekly help-room hours. Ranked top 3 of 25 TAs; recommended for ISU Teaching Excellence Award.
- Graduate Mentor, “Saturday Morning Breakfast Club” Spring 2023 – Present
Mentor undergraduate and graduate students through their own research projects in a weekly research program in the ISU Department of Economics, founded by Peter Orazem in 2014. Advise students on research questions and data sources, and guide them through dataset construction, cleaning, and Stata programming. Several papers listed above originated in Breakfast Club collaborations.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Doctoral

- Research Assistant (quarter-time), Iowa State University Fall 2026
Ongoing analysis of the ISU Alumni Survey data with Prof. Peter F. Orazem.
- Extension Research Collaboration, Iowa State University Fall 2026
Extension work with Dr. Rabail Chandio on the Iowa Farmland Tenure and Ownership Survey and related outreach articles.
- Research Assistant, Iowa State University Summer 2025
Led data construction and analysis for rural–urban migration patterns across ISU Alumni Survey cohorts.
- Research Assistant, Iowa State University Summer 2024
Supported the 2024 ISU Alumni Survey data pipeline; cleaned raw Qualtrics survey responses, constructed employment and entrepreneurship measures, and produced descriptive tabulations used in subsequent policy reports and working papers.
- Research Assistant, Iowa State University Spring 2024
Contributed empirical analysis to college-town business-cycle resilience project; assisted with data construction and supported undergraduate researchers.

Pre-Doctoral (India)

- Research Assistant, Indian School of Business Summer 2022
Contributed to pilot RCT evaluating Bihar’s Public Distribution System; managed survey logistics and data cleaning.
- Research Assistant, IFMR LEAD Aug 2021 – Mar 2022
Analyzed differential impacts of COVID-19 on mental well-being of men and women using difference-in-differences; data analysis in Stata and geo-coding in R and Google API. PIs: Amrita Dhillon (KCL), Farzana Afridi (ISI Delhi), Sanchari Roy (KCL).

- Research Assistant, King’s College London Jun 2020 – Jul 2021
Developed composite measures of state performance for MGNREGA and PMGSY; supervised team of RAs for data quality control of large administrative dataset. PIs: Amrita Dhillon (KCL), Farzana Afridi (ISI Delhi), Arka Roy Chaudhury (Shiv Nadar).

HONORS AND AWARDS

- USDA AMS–AAEA Local Food Economics Data Visualization Challenge (First Place, \$1,200 team prize) 2026
“Mapping the Missing Market Pathways in U.S. Dairy Regions,” with A. Basha and H. Lee.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

- Referee: *Growth and Change, Journal of Development Effectiveness*
- Session Moderator, Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA) Jul 2026
- Session Moderator, Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting Nov 2026
- Discussant, Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting Mar 2025
- Elected Chair, College of Liberal Arts & Sciences, Graduate & Professional Student Senate, ISU 2023–2024
- Senator, Department of Economics, Graduate & Professional Student Senate, ISU 2023–2024
- Member: American Economic Association; Agricultural & Applied Economics Association; Midwest Economics Association

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- Mentee, Association for Mentoring and Inclusion in Economics (AMIE) 2025–2026
- Preparing Future Faculty Course (GRST 5850), Iowa State University Fall 2025

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Software: Stata, R, Python, L^AT_EX, Google API (geo-coding), Excel

Data: IPUMS (CPS, ACS, Decennial Census), USDA NASS Census of Agriculture, DOL H-2A administrative records, ISU Alumni Survey, NSSO (India), DISE (India education)

Methods: Panel data, difference-in-differences, shift-share/Bartik IV, event study, regression discontinuity, RCT design and evaluation

Languages: English (fluent), Hindi (native)

REFERENCES

Dr. John V. Winters
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Dr. Peter F. Orazem
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University Professor
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267 Heady Hall
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Dr. Amani Elobeid
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